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Title:

Shakespeare in Like

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Publication Date: September 1, 2022

Published by

MUSHROOM CLOUD PRESS

U.S.A.

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SHAKESPEARE IN LIKE

A Humorous Duo Script

By Shawn LaSota

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CHARACTERS:

WILLIAM: It's William Shakespeare, a somewhat oblivious man trying to write a romantic poem that is less than flattering to the woman he is trying to woo.

WOMAN:	A blunt woman with a shrill voice that makes nails on chalkboards and fighting cats sound like a symphony. She is not an intellectual woman, but serves as the comedic and down-to-earth voice of reason within the play.

Synopsis:

William Shakespeare is trying to make his lady swoon by writing Sonnet 130 and reciting it to her. Unfortunately, it does not turn out to be as flattering as intended, and this mistress does not mince words with her dissatisfaction.

SHAKESPEARE IN LIKE

WILLIAM and WOMAN are at center stage. He has a book open in front of him along with a quill, violently scribbling. The WOMAN is bored, looking around at the scenery and sighing loudly for WILLIAM's attention. He acknowledges this by glancing over his shoulder with an annoyed expression.

WOMAN:

Willy, I'm bored…

WILLIAM:

William, please, darling. Just a moment longer.

WOMAN:

But you're taking so looooooong.

William:

(*under his breath)*And yet, it will take longer the more that you interrupt me with your incessant whining.

WOMAN:

Did you say something?

WILLIAM:

No, darling. Of course not.

(William reads over what he has just written, dabs his notebook with his quill once more and beams at his beloved)

William:

Finished. Possibly my greatest sonnet yet, darling, and it is all for you.

Woman:

What's a sonnet?

WILLIAM:

A what now?

WOMAN:

You said “sonnet.” What’s a sonnet?

WILLIAM:

Well, it’s a poem. A lyrical sort, I suppose. It is fourteen lines long. Three quatrains and a final couplet. All of it is written in iambic pentameter.

WOMAN:

I am big what?

WILLIAM:

Iambic pentameter. It means 5 feet of 10 syllables paired into stressed and unstressed rhythm that...you know what...never mind.

WOMAN:

Well, I’ve never heard of any poem like that before.

WILLIAM:

I know, I just sort of, you know, created it.

WOMAN:

You did? Really? Well, what are you going to call these types of sonnets?

WILLIAM:

I’m going to call them...Shakespearian Sonnets.

WOMAN:

Really?

WILLIAM:

What?

WOMAN:

A little on the nose, don’t you think?

WILLIAM:

What’s wrong with it?

WOMAN:
I just think a guy that writes a lot about hubris being a downfall to several characters ought to be a little bit less full of himself.

WILLIAM:
Ah, well...maybe you’re right. I’m sure someone else will come up with a better name for this type of sonnet. But alas, I have finished and it is perhaps the most romantic sonnet I’ve ever written...and it was entirely inspired by you, my love.

WOMAN:
Really? Oh my God. What’s it called?

WILLIAM:
Sonnet...130.

WOMAN:
Seriously?

WILLIAM:
What?

WOMAN:
That’s the best you’ve got. Sonnet 130?

WILLIAM:
Well, it’s the 130th one I’ve written.

WOMAN:
So you can write super long plays, but you can’t name a 14-line sonnet?

WILLIAM:
I’ll worry about it later. Would you like to hear it?

WOMAN:
Who were the 129 others for? Huh? How many other women have you written sonnets for?

WILLIAM:
Probably not as many as you'd think.

WOMAN:
What?

WILLIAM:
Nothing, my love. Would you like me to recite it to you?

WOMAN:
I suppose…

WILLIAM:
(clears throat) My mistress's eyes are nothing like the sun; Coral is far more red than her lips' red; If snow be white, why then her breasts are dun; If hairs be wires, black wires grow on her head. I have seen…

WOMAN:
Are you out of your mind?

WILLIAM:
I'm sorry, my love?

WOMAN:
What did you say about me? You balding one earring wearing son of a…

WILLIAM:
What is the matter, my dear?

WOMAN:
My eyes aren't like the sun? My skin is pale? My hair is like wires growing out of my head? And what on Earth did you say about my breasts? Dun? What the hell is that? Sounds like you're calling them a nasty grayish-brown color…

WILLIAM:
(*nervously)*No, it means they're...um...wonderful.

WOMAN:

It better. If this poem doesn’t turn around fast, then I’m going to make it so it's your skull some Danish guy in a leotard is having a conversation with, if you catch my drift.

WILLIAM:

Yes, dear. It will all make sense in due time. *(clears throat)* I have seen roses damask, red and white, but no such roses see I in her cheeks; And in some perfumes is there more delight than in the breath that from my mistress reeks.

WOMAN:

You think my breath stinks! Who the hell do you think you are?

WILLIAM:

Please, my dear, I promise the romance is coming. If you’ll only be patient.

WOMAN:

I can’t wait for you to see what I’m going to get you for your birthday…

WILLIAM:

(clears throat) I love to hear her speak, yet well I know that music hath a far more pleasing sound...Crap...I heard it as I said it.

WOMAN:

So I have an annoying voice now?

WILLIAM:

Nagging at best, my love.

WOMAN:

You vile standing tuck!

WILLIAM:

Hey, that’s good. Can I borrow that?

WOMAN:

Get on with it!

William:

Okay, okay. I promise you, you'll see that this is really super romantic. I grant I never saw a goddess go; My mistress, when she walks, treads on the ground.

WOMAN:

So now I'm not graceful? Do I walk like I'm dragging a wooden leg?

WILLIAM:

For the love of...will you just hold on?

WOMAN:

This poem is one big insult. Apparently, I'm ugly, plain, colorless, stinky, and have an annoying voice. The only kind thing in it is what you said about my breasts being dun. *(looks down at herself)* And you're darn right they are.

WILLIAM:

Here it is, my dear, the last couplet. I promise you will see that this was all with good intention. And yet, by heaven, I think my love as rare as any she belied with false compare.

WOMAN:

Go on…

WILLIAM:

Well, that's it. That's the end of the sonnet.

WOMAN:

Are you kidding me right now?

WILLIAM:

It's romantic.

WOMAN:

Where? When? What part of that was intended to make me swoon and like you, huh?

WILLIAM:

That couplet...it means that...well, even though you are not perfect, I love you in spite of all of those imperfections.

WOMAN:

(sarcastic) Well, aren't you just a knight in shining armor? How did I ever get so lucky to find a guy that would put up with my bad breath and annoying voice? What can I possibly do to show you my appreciation? You can dip your quill in my ink any time you want.

WILLIAM:

Do you really like it?

WOMAN:

No, you idiot. No woman wants to be told about her imperfections. We know them already, duh! We already know that we stink and fart and burp and do all the gross things that men do.

WILLIAM:

(*cringes)* You do those things?

WOMAN:

I will cut you, William. I'm in no mood! Yeah, we do those things, but we don't want to be reminded of them and we don't want you to make it like you're taking one for the team by putting up with our bodily functions. We want to be spoiled. We want to be made to feel like the only woman in your world. We want to feel like goddesses and queens.

WILLIAM:

Is that what you really want?

WOMAN:

William, you've written such amazing love scenes...how have you still not figured out what women want?

WILLIAM:

Well, the women in my plays are acted by men.

WOMAN:

Figures. Women want to swoon. And no woman is going to swoon over being told that her breath stinks, you idiot.

WILLIAM:

So, if I...compare you to say...a summer's day? But say that you're more lovely and more temperate...you'd be into that?

WOMAN:

Keep talking.

WILLIAM:

If I said things like...um...Rough winds do shake the darling buds of May, And summer's lease hath all too short a date...

WOMAN:

Go on.

WILLIAM:

Sometimes too hot the eye of heaven shines, and often is his gold complexion dimm'd; And every fair from fair sometime declines, By chance or nature's changing course untrimm'd.

WOMAN:

Can't trust that weather. Go on, baby, tell me more.

WILLIAM:

(turns to her) But thy eternal summer shall not fade, nor lose possession of that fair thou ow'st.

WOMAN:

Mmmm, now we're cookin'.

WILLIAM:

Nor shall death brag thou wander'st in his shade, when in eternal lines to time thou grow'st: So long as men can breathe or eyes can see, so long lives this, and this gives life to thee.

WOMAN:

Oh, William, that was beautiful. Just wonderful. Did you come up with that right off the top of your head just for me?

WILLIAM:

Um, yes. I totally didn’t have that pre-written and it most definitely wasn’t for a man.

WOMAN:

That’s a really odd and specific thing to say.

WILLIAM:

Fair enough.

WOMAN:

Oh, William, that was just what I needed to hear. I love you, my darling.

WILLIAM:

And I you, my love.

(They embrace)

WOMAN:

Enough to give me your favorite bed?

WILLIAM:

Well, I mean, let’s not rush into anything.

End Scene